Ms Tenacity

VAISHALI RAMESHBABU, 24
Grandmaster, Chess
Chennai



When Vaishali Rameshbabu, 24, reached the shores of Pegeia, Cyprus, in March to compete in what was her second straight Candidates, not many expected her to win a tournament whose victor gets to challenge the world champion. And rightly so. She had the lowest ELO rating among the eight-woman field, and came with a mixed bag in 2025-26, which saw her struggle for consistency. In fact, it was Vaishali's younger brother, R. Praggnanandhaa, who was seen as the more solid bet to handle the rigours of one of the toughest classical chess tournaments.

But here's the thing about Vaishali. She isn't a lioness on the 64 squares; she's more a sly fox, crafting and calculating her way to stifle the opponent till they are left with little to manoeuvre. Playing with white pieces against Divya Deshmukh, she avoided her compatriot's opening preparation to wrap up the game in just 31 moves; and, against Aleksandra Goryachkina, she piled up the pressure and provoked a mistake.

"She has this great tenacity to her," says five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand. "Even when she is struggling in a tournament, she is able to keep it together and keep playing; and even when she is losing, she is never fully lost, turning a lot of games in difficult moments." It's exactly what she did at Candidates, a feat that made the social media-shy youngster only the second Indian woman since Koneru Humpy (2011) to fight for the title that's eluded India so far. Her match-up against world champ Ju Wenjun awaits FIDE scheduling.

When it comes to discipline, most agree that it's hard to rival Vaishali. "She was already a very hardworking player when she came to me," says R.B. Ramesh, coach to Indian sport's most famous siblings. "She is reserved around strangers and jovial with her close ones." It's perhaps why you won't see this Gen-Zer posting a reel on Instagram. She knows the real stories are written on the board by outwitting the world's best. It's why a nation believes that it will have its first female world champion by 2027. ■

— Suhani Singh

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Won the gruelling Candidates 2026 which gets Vaishali a straight shot at the world champion crown

HER TAKE

After winning the FIDE Candidates tournament in Pegeia in Cyprus, Vaishali Rameshbabu had this message for all young Indian girls pursuing chess: "Just enjoy the game. There is more to it than the game itself. Play a lot of tournaments and enjoy the process"